constitutional amendment proposals of 2015.

Given that Myanmar has not had a bicameral parliament since 1962, the introduction of a bicameral Union Parliament is a significant feature of the initial structural reforms. The first laws passed in anticipation of the functioning of parliament related to the powers, roles, and responsibilities of the Pyithu Hluttaw, the Amyotha Hluttaw, and the Pyidaungsu Hluttaw.[2] The Union Parliament has authority to pass legislation within the eleven areas allocated to it under the constitution, which are broad in scope. The list of legislative matters includes: defence and security; foreign affairs; finance and planning; economy; agriculture; energy, electricity, forestry and mining; industry; transport, communication, and construction; social sector (education, health); management; and the judiciary. The Union Parliament has residual legislative power, while a narrow range of powers are elaborated for the states and regions. The lawmaking process is heavily centralized, and legislative power has been the subject of constitutional amendment, rather than judicial interpretation. The amendments approved in July 2015 set out further details of the legislative and taxation powers of the states and regions,[3] which suggest that courts are less likely to play a role in the interpretation of the scope of these powers.

In addition, the state and region governments have been established with their own unicameral parliaments and a limited measure of independence from the union government.[4] While the most controversial aspect has been that the president appoints the chief ministers of the states and regions, an unsuccessful attempt was made in 2015 to amend the constitution so that chief ministers could be appointed by a majority of elected representatives. The desire for greater devolution of power to the states and regions and independence of the Hluttaws from the central government are likely to lead to further reform in the future.

At both the central and regional levels of governance, changes to the rules on elections have been another area of reform. Prior to 2010, Myanmar had not held elections for ten years, and so the Union Election Commission was reconstituted to oversee the electoral process.[5] In addition, legislation has been passed on the electoral process in relation to each of these houses and levels of government,[6] as well as for the registration of political parties more generally.[7] One of the key issues that arose was the possibility of proportional representation. The debate on whether to replace the first past the post system with proportional representation, covered in more detail by Lidauer (this volume) generated conflict between the